

These North Chennai communities are turning collective effort into lasting change **P3**

MEET THE CAST OF *PYAAR PREMA KALYANAM* **P4**



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Meena Kandasamy has never been shy about having her work challenge the Left – her own political community. For years now, this award-winning poet-novelist’s critique has taken the shape of Facebook posts, and tweets. Now, more recently, it takes the shape of a book that is a sharp and frankly hilarious take-down of the Indian manosphere.

“When you identify yourself with something, a movement, you not only have responsibilities but you also have duties. I have always been trying to point out what is happening within the Left which I think is problematic. One of the things that they have not yet come to terms with is how they treat women and how they treat sexuality,” she says.

Meena is all set to be in conversation with Vaishna Roy, Editor, *Frontline*, at the *The Hindu Lit for Life Unplugged* event titled Women, Power & Desire on August 21 at Amethyst’s Wild Garden Bar. Ahead of the event, she speaks about the years of online abuse that shaped how she writes about the Internet, and her decades-long tug-of-war with Chennai.

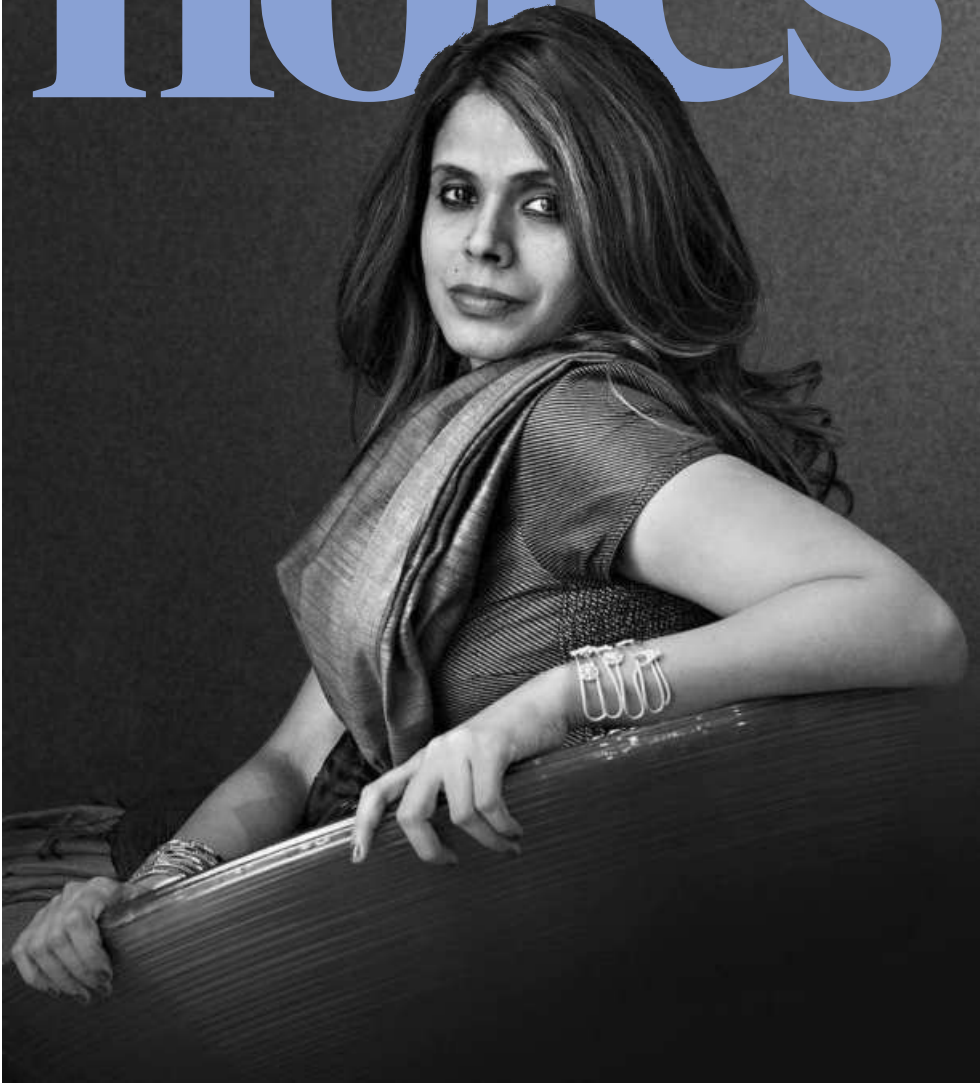
What’s in a name?

Meena says that she has trained her fiction on the failures of the political Left – from the collapse of electoral Marxism in *Gypsy Goddess* to the way progressive men can weaponise left-wing language to shame women in *When I Hit You*. “If it’s the devil, it will quote the scripture – so they can even quote Marx and justify their ways. The left contends with women ans the question of sexuality,” she says.

Over the years, Meena has observed that the Left also takes to a selective feudalism that calls out superstition and deference to power, but leaves

Ahead of her conversation at *The Hindu Lit for Life Unplugged* on August 21, poet-novelist Meena Kandasamy talks about surviving over a decade of Internet abuse, and why Chennai keeps pulling her back

No notes



Decoding the incel

Author Meena Kandasamy.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

its own attitudes toward women and desire unexamined. That critique plays out through Amy, *Fieldwork As A Sex Worker’s* protagonist, who was deliberately built as someone very unlike herself. Amy is unlikable but surely important enough to take notice of. “It had to be someone from Delhi. She had to be a student who would go to the frontlines, to Jamia. It is only there that cases like UAPA are slapped callously on students. The national media would take notice only if she was from there and write the headlines that it chooses to. It could not have been someone from here (Chennai),” she says.

With *Fieldwork*, published by Harper Collins, introducing several characters that represent society’s myriad follies – of a lower caste Tamil woman who helps an Eelam Tamil soldier, a ditsy white activist – Meena spends time shaping the characters, besides that of the protagonist, who have their own separate arcs so they are not reduced to tropes.

Meena says that her broader process of building characters involves disciplined listening. “You really have to go pick the details of what makes them specific – how they move around the world, how they treat each other, what are the tensions,”

she says. She adds that writing other people requires retreating into oneself and toning down her own personality so a book stays about its subject rather than its author. It is why when approaching a deadline, Meena escapes to a hotel room for about five days somewhere near her house – the perfect distance for her to access her children.

The author says that until her second child was born, much of the Internet was in the dark about her having been a mother. There are parts of herself that she fiercely guards, calling social media nothing but a careful curation of what she would like to show about her life. Shielding

spectrum – from Tamil nationalist groups angered by her translation work on the *Thirukkural*, to backlash after she publicly opposed the DMK. “It is quite something to wake up to a million notifications on something that you said being misconstrued as something else entirely,” she says. Her way of coping, she says, has been to treat the hostility as directed at a caricature. “None of these people who abuse me actually know me. This is the person they made up in their mind, and they decide to hate that person.”

A city of love

Fieldwork was largely written while Meena lived in London and, later, Puducherry, and she resists calling it a Chennai book. Still, the city comes up repeatedly and personally to her. “I have been trying to run away from Chennai since I was 25,” she says, half-joking that it feels like a curse. “Despite whatever I’ve done to get away from here, I’ve always ended up coming back. It is a city of heartbreak and love for me,” she says. To her, the monsoon is a season of permitted melancholy: “I’m actually happy this time of the year, because from September it’s going to start raining and I can keep crying – all my melancholy can be folded into these four months,” she says, laughing.

Meena’s conversation at *The Hindu Lit for Life Unplugged* is expected to expand on these threads – the politics of *Fieldwork*, the ethics of writing characters far from her own experience, and what it means to keep writing in public after more than a decade of being targeted for it.

Women, Power & Desire: A conversation with Meena Kandasamy, author, and Vaishna Roy, Editor, Frontline, is on August 21 at Amethyst’s Wild Garden Bar. The event is at 6pm. Registration is mandatory: newsth.live/LFLUNP.

STEPOUT



Rethinking heritage

This Madras Day, Global Shapers Community Chennai, a youth volunteering initiative under the World Economic Forum, Heritage Inspired, a cultural organisation working around living heritage, and Art Kin Centre, a Chennai-based art centre, come together for Madras Reimagined – a day-long

programme bringing history, civic action and art into conversation about the city. Madras before Madras by Parvathy Peter (9.15am to 9.40am); Who are we to Madras? by Neeraj Bharadwaj (9.45am to 10.20am); Heritage beyond conservation, by Shalini Ravikumar (10.25am to 10.45am), and panel discussion (11am to 12.30pm). For morning session ticket, priced at ₹149, email: themadrasday@gmail.com. @Art Kin Centre, Alwarpet. August 22.



Capture this

The Chennai Photo Biennale (CPB) International Open Call returns for its third edition on World Photography Day, August 19, inviting photographers and artists of all ages from across the world to submit their work. In partnership with SIGMA India, the open call

welcomes photographic and lens-based practices spanning documentary, portraiture, landscape, Nature, still life, conceptual and experimental work. There is no prescribed theme, and both single images and series are eligible. The jury includes Bhavna Kakkar, Charan Singh, Indrajit Khambe, Nat Geo Explorer and World Press Photo winner Senthil Kumaran, photographer and educator Vineet Vohra, Uma Bista, Umah Jacob of India Art Fair, and Ushmita Sahu of Emami Art. Selected works will be exhibited in Chennai in January/February 2027. The open call is open until October 31, 2026. Details on eligibility, submission criteria on Chennai Photo Biennale Foundation website and Instagram.

Elsa Sunny

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Like any other metropolitan city, Chennai is always on the move, chasing dreams and livelihoods. But in every nook and corner of the city – between the bricks of its colonial buildings and the folds of its shorelines – lie thousands of stories, told and untold. The city reveals this side to those who pause and observe it.

“There is nothing like Chennai in the early morning light. The best time to photograph architectural buildings is between 5.30am and 7am, especially when the sky is cloudy,” says Kiran Sa. In his photograph, the Senate House of the University of Madras stands with its ornate arches and domes in the soft morning light. During the early days of his career, Kiran says these structures turned into informal classrooms as he practised capturing these buildings to understand light, exposure and framing.

Photographer Noor Nisha’s lens follows the lesser documented corners in the northern region of Chennai. Her favourite photograph, taken from Kosasthalaiyar River near the Ennore Creek, captures a woman from the Irular tribal community catching prawns for a livelihood.

“The photo also portrays the struggles of women. Although the river is polluted, they have



Postcards from Chennai

Against the backdrop of World Photography Day on August 19, five photographers look back at their favourite frames of Chennai

no option but to depend on it,” she says. As a woman from North Chennai, she feels deeply connected with the region and subject of the photograph. “North Chennai is often portrayed in a negative light. I want to show the other side of it, beyond the stereotypes,” she says.

As much as Chennai is shaped by its struggles, it is also a city defined by the unity and resilience of its people. One such moment was captured by

photographer Kabilan AP in 2012 at Elliot’s Beach when Cyclone Nilam drove the oil tanker MT Pratibha aground.

“We all stood helpless, but suddenly a fisherman’s boat was speeding into the waters. When they finally managed to rescue the drowning crew, the whole crowd went wild. The fishing boat went back twice, battling strong waves and winds. However, they managed to rescue most of the crew,” he says, recalling the story behind

Steady hands (Clockwise from left) The Senate House; Poster of *Boys*; and a woman catching prawn.

KIRAN SA, G VENKET RAM AND NOOR NISHA



his photograph. Expressing his strong dream of documenting the lives of people in the city, he says, “the heart of Chennai is the people in it.” The strength and courage of the city is not only visible in moments of crisis but

also in the frames of everyday life. Neha Samuel’s portrait of a flower vendor on a street in Perambur captures one such moment. The photograph captures a woman carrying a stool on her head as she makes her way to sell flowers. “The morning light made her shadow appear bigger. She was just an ordinary woman carrying a stool on her head, but when I looked at her shadow, it felt like she was carrying something much bigger – her struggles and her dreams,” she says.

For generations, Chennai has also been remembered through its cinema. “Earlier, film publicity in Madras relied on painters who would create huge hand-painted hoardings. But in the late 1990s and early 2000s, digital prints and flex hoardings changed the way films were advertised,” says G Venket Ram, who has been working behind the camera for 30 years. Recalling the poster shoot for the 2003 Tamil film *Boys*, he says that with social media yet to enter the publicity landscape, film promotions at the time relied on billboards, posters and print advertisements. “We would shoot different pictures – a romantic shot, an action shot or just an expression – and these were used for flex hoardings, CD covers, posters and newspaper advertisements.”

A city can be many things at once – a wonder, a dream or a memory. All it takes is a moment to pause, look a little closer and let Chennai tell its story.



Vignettes from the past (Left) A vintage photograph of Buhari Hotel on Anna Salai; (below) Janata Sappad being handed over to customers. THE HINDU ARCHIVES



plate

Actors Nalini Nair, Nassar, and Pasupathy speak about their food memories, favourite Chennai joints, and childhood treats

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Nalini Nair

Veteran actor Nalini Nair, a familiar face for television audiences, was born and raised in Chennai. She entered the Tamil film industry with *Raanuva Veeran* (1981) and went on to make a mark in Telugu, Kannada and Malayalam films as well. After a hiatus from acting in 1988, Nalini ventured into television with *Krishna Daasi* in 2000. There has been no looking back since.

A long-time resident of Valasaravakkam, Nalini has fond memories of a Udupi hotel on Kodambakkam High Road, which she frequented with her siblings. “My siblings and I used to love the idlis at this hotel. For two idlis, we would literally drink a litre of sambar,” she chuckles.

Her family’s celebratory

meals in the 1970s and ’80s often meant a visit to Impala Hotel in Anna Salai. “It was here that my Amma introduced us to chole bhatura and falooda for the first time. The taste and the experience are etched in my memory,” she recalls. Sadly this restaurant no longer exists.

These days, her favourite spot for idli, dosa and sambar is any branch of Geetham. For non-vegetarian food, she always prefers to order from New Andhra Meals Hotel in Valasaravakkam. “I especially love their gongura chicken. When it is on their menu, I will get a call from the owner,” she says. “These days, I rarely eat out, except when my son and daughter take me out for dinner. Unlike me, they prefer Japanese or Korean food. Recently, I enjoyed the taste of ramen, which suited my palate.”



My siblings and I used to love the idlis at this Udupi hotel. For two idlis, we would literally drink a litre of sambar

NALINI
Actor

Nassar

Actor Nassar, who made his debut with *Kalyana Agathigal* in 1985 and rose to fame with his role as a police officer in Mani Ratnam’s *Nayakan* (1987), has spent much of his life in Chennai. As a youngster fascinated by the city, the actor would travel from Chengalpattu with his father for a monthly Parry’s Corner business visit. Here, they would eat a bun-butter-jam and tea from Kamadhenu Supermarket in Teynampet. During his PUC days, Nassar’s favourite haunt was Kuralagam in Parry’s Corner, where he would drink bottled pathaneer from Khadi Kraft and have ‘cone ice cream’, which was a rare sight back then.

His working life in Chennai also introduced him to food he had never tasted before. Nassar joined Taj Coromandel as a waiter and worked there from 1979 to 1982. “It was during this time that I tasted cheese for the first time. I also got caught red-handed tasting Hungarian goulash soup without permission.” During his film institute days, however, food was more about sustenance than indulgence. Aavin

flavoured milk and Modern bread became his breakfast.

Nassar also remembers a Government scheme that helped people like him get an affordable meal when money was tight. “Not many in Chennai today may be aware that there was once a Government scheme to protect ordinary citizens from rising food prices,” he says, referring to Janata Sappad.

He also remembers the Burmese mohinga sold near Beach Station which he has frequented with his wife Kameela. Another favourite during their dating days was the rooftop eatery on the third floor of Khadi Bhavan on Anna Salai.

“After having tiffin there, we would climb down and drink sukku coffee sold on the ground floor. The canteen is no longer in existence, but I miss it dearly.”

Woodlands Drive-in is another vanished Chennai landmark that Nassar remembers fondly. “For many aspiring artistes from various fields, it was a meeting place where lively conversations would go on for hours.”

Today their favourite is Bask in Alwarpet, and the family also tries Korean and Japanese restaurants. “My heart still leads me back to the Burmese food sold in pushcarts and Aavin flavoured milk,” he says.

Pasupathy

After making his Tamil film debut as Kothala Thevar in Kamal Haasan’s



Crafted across India

Santhe brings together the rich craft traditions of India under one roof, with 90 craft groups and artisans from 21 states showcasing their work. From Chanderi, tussar and Maheshwari weaves to ajrak, kalamkari, shibori, block prints, dhokra jewellery, terracotta, bamboo crafts and moonj baskets, the 30-day bazaar offers a glimpse into India’s textile and craft heritage. Visitors can also shop directly from artisans, explore live craft demonstrations, enjoy traditional food, and experience dance performances and workshops. The showcase highlights sustainable and revival crafts while supporting artisan livelihoods. @Sri Sankara Hall, Alwarpet. Till September 13, from 10am to 8 pm. Entry is free.



A feast to be shared

Experience traditional Bohri cuisine over meaningful conversations. Curated by Jumjo, which provides such food experiences, this shared meal, served over eight courses, is meant to be enjoyed together. Non-vegetarian meal is priced at ₹2,300 and vegetarian ₹1,900. @Backyard, Adyar. On August 23, with slots at 1pm and 2.30pm. To pre-book, call 9344665986.



Threads of tradition
Kachchi Mitti brings together a curated selection of sustainable fashion brands, curated by Sanchita Ghosh. The textile exhibition celebrates Indian crafts and heritage weaves from different states. @CP Art Centre, Alwarpet. August 20-22, 11am to 8pm. Entry is free

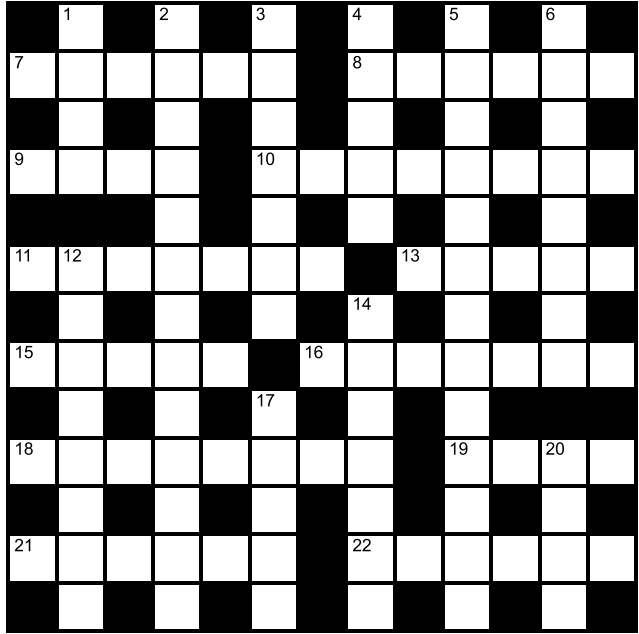


Rasanai

At Rasanai in Besant Nagar, celebrate Onam with a traditional sadya, bringing together a generous spread of festive flavours and time-honoured recipes. The meal features classics such as thoran, aviyal, olan, erissery, kaalan, pachadi, kichidi, kootu curry and sambar, alongside kuthari choru and parippu curry. To finish, there is chakka pradhaman and paalada pradhaman, with poovan pazham and sambharam. From August 17 to 26, priced at ₹1,725 per person for dine-in and ₹2,845 including taxes for takeaway, serving two. For reservations, call 8925915856.



METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #67
(Set by Doppelganger)



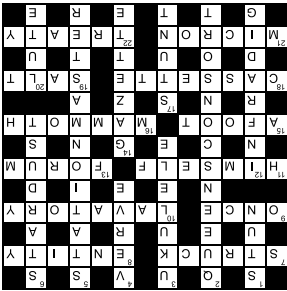
- Across**
- 7 Hit (6)
 - 8 Being (6)
 - 9 A single occurrence (4)
 - 10 Sanitary installation (8)
 - 11 Emphasizes 'he' (7)
 - 13 Meeting place (5)
 - 15 Ongoing (5)
 - 16 Extinct animal of Pleistocene epoch (7)
 - 18 Tape container that was a rage in 1980s (8)
 - 19 Informal term for sailor (4)
 - 21 One millionth of a metre (6)
 - 22 Formal agreement (6)
- Down**
- 1 Surprise (4)
 - 2 Reigning King's wife (6,7)
 - 3 Stringed instrument of Hawaiian origin (7)
 - 4 Enthusiasm (5)
 - 5 Senior railway official (13)
 - 6 Romanticism (8)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



- 12 Beneath one's dignity (5,3)
- 14 Official journal (7)
- 17 Daring feat (5)
- 20 Old-fashioned stringed instrument (4)

Solution No. 67



Southern Spice

This Onam, Southern Spice at Taj Coromandel brings Kerala's festive traditions to the table with an elaborate vegetarian Onam plate, prepared using traditional recipes. The feast begins with ona sambharam, a refreshing spiced buttermilk infused with ginger, green chilli, and curry leaves, followed by a spread of festive favourites. The dessert course brings ada pradhaman, paruppu payasam, alli pidi, and njaalipoovan.

On August 25 and 26 for lunch and dinner, priced at ₹3,600 plus taxes per person. For reservations, call 66002827.



Sashwatha Cafe

Sashwatha Cafe is celebrating Onam with a traditional sadya featuring a festive spread of curries, accompaniments, and pickles. The sadya includes classics such as paruppu, sambar, moru curry, beetroot pachadi, olan, rasam, cabbage thoran, pineapple kalan, mathanga erissery and avial, along with Kerala matta rice, lemon pickle, mango pickle, inji puli, sharkara varatti and banana chips.

Available on August 25 and 26, the sadya is priced at ₹495 per person exclusive of taxes for dine-in. For reservations, call 9994131222. This is only at the Anna Nagar outlet.

Where to sadya

From classic Kerala preparations to family recipes, here are some sadya options to try

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Visesham

Visesham’s Onam involves festive favourites, available as a dine-in meal for two as well as a takeaway box for those celebrating at home. The spread features classics such as avial, olan, thoran, pachadi, kootu curry, chemba rice, mooru, pallakadan sambar, thalicha thayir, along with three different types of payasam: paal ari payasam, paruppu payasam, and paalada payasam, and manga achar.



From August 19 to 26, the dine-in meal for two is priced at ₹1,799 plus taxes, available from 12pm to 3.30pm. The Onam sadya takeaway box, serving two, is priced at ₹2,999 and is available from August 19 to 26. For reservation call, 91767 57755 Visesham, Nandanam.



Kappa Chakka Kandhari

Kappa Chakka Kandhari is celebrating Onam with a traditional Kerala Onam sadya served across August 25 and 26, bringing together an elaborate spread of festive favourites. The menu features cheru pazham, kootu kari, sarkara varattiyathu, cabbage thoran, nendrakai nuruku, and many more dishes.

An Onam sadya box is also available for those looking to celebrate at home. Dine in is ₹1,980 per head for adults and ₹1,180 for children including taxes. For reservations, call, 9858591010.

Young Challenge Sports Club and Social Welfare Association, Thiruvottriyur

For 40 years now, Young Challenge Sports Club and Social Welfare Association (YCSC), has been using sports as a means to instil confidence and a sense of purpose in children in Thiruvottriyur. The club, started by K Chinnasamy from the neighbourhood when he was in his early 20s, was called Lenin Sports Club in its initial days. “He wanted to prevent youngsters from getting trapped in the world of substance abuse,” says KN Prabhakaran, the vice president of the club and nephew of the founder.

When it was first started, YCSC was a space for school children to gather in the evenings for a game of cricket or football. “It then expanded into a free tuition centre,” says Prabhakaran, adding that some 40 children would meet on the terrace of his home for classes. “When more students wanted to join, a local school let us use its premises for tuitions.”

Back then, the boys and girls played at the Wimco Nagar grounds, and seniors who passed out presented talks on career growth. Today, the club has discontinued the evening tuitions, but continues to support children from the locality who enjoy sports. “We meet once a week at a turf that we book for a subsidised cost for football and cricket practice,” says the 38-year-old.

Among their key events is a rally they undertake every year

in North Chennai, raising slogans against casteism. Prabhakaran, who is employed at a private firm in the city, says that students from the club have gone on to build successful careers in various fields. “We also hold regular discussions on socio-economic issues, without going deep into politics,” he says.

Another field that the YCSC focusses on is the arts. “There are around 10 schools in our neighbourhood and we hold art and literary events every year. For this, we have commissioned a rolling trophy,” says Prabhakaran. YCSC is among the oldest such establishments in North Chennai, and continues to embrace children across generations in its fold.

They have a dream
Youth-led movements with a focus on sports, education, and environment have brought about tremendous change in North Chennai. Here, we look at three such initiatives that inspire

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Vyasai Thozhargal, Vyasarpadi

What began as an informal gathering of a group of friends who played cricket together, has now grown into a voluntary movement with purpose in Vyasarpadi. N Sakthivel, a documentary photographer who is the coordinator of Vyasai Thozhargal, recalls how all of them

would talk about the caste-based discrimination they faced in school when they met. “I did my higher secondary in a school in Besant Nagar,” says Sakthivel: “Some students there would not call me by my name and would address me as ‘Vyasarpadi’ instead.”

When he realised they were mocking him since he was from a disadvantaged locality, he channelled his anger towards sports.



“I won several trophies for my school. Once, they called my name in the assembly to congratulate me. The name ‘Sakthivel’ rang through the campus,” he says. It is a moment he will never forget. “It made me understand how important sports

and education were for one’s self-worth,” he says, adding that these fields are the primary focus of Vyasai Thozhargal.

The movement was started by Sarath Kumar, an advocate along with president, Prem Kumar, who is also an advocate; and R Vijayalakshmi, a teacher. She teaches at the Dr Ambedkar Pagutharivu Padasalai, their free tuition centre in the evenings. Here, one of the more important lessons is to use the tools that we have, to ask important questions; the RTI Act, for example.

Over the years, Vyasai Thozhargal has been amplifying the voices of people from North Chennai. Their army of volunteers participate in relief work during natural calamities. Sakthivel says they named their tuition centre after Ambedkar because of their love for the leader. And also because *pagutharivu* or rational thinking is crucial for a casteless society.



Singaravelar Padippagam, Ennore

While Singaravelar Padippagam was started as a tuition centre for Government school students in Ennore, it has now grown into a space for environmental awareness. “It was started in 2015 in a 600 sq ft hall in a building in Ennore,” says Devi Hariharan from the centre. “Children arrive at 6pm after school. We have teachers taking classes till 8pm,” she adds.

Among their biggest achievements is preventing children from dropping out of school. “This used to be a huge problem for Government schools in our locality since most parents are from the working class and are busy through the day,” she says. “Even class VIII students would find it difficult to read and write.” But now, with the support of teachers at the centre, many of them have gone on to score good marks in their Board exams.

Students at Singaravelar Padippagam are environmentally aware thanks to their regular interactions with activists and environmentalists

such as Nityanand Jayaraman who hold informal discussions with them on a regular basis. “We’ve also had students from IIT Madras interact with our students,” adds Devi, who is part of the Tamil Nadu Science Forum.

Over the years, Devi has taken it upon herself to offer emotional support for children from abusive families. She recalls how a pre-teen, who was often found to be withdrawn, finally started making friends at the centre after years of going through trauma at home.

Children from the centre regularly take up projects for the National Children’s Science Congress, says Bhagath Singh, one of the founders. Among their key projects, he adds, is one that discussed the pollution that plagues the Kosasthalaiyar river that enters the sea through Ennore. “Another event we would regularly organise is the Ennore Book Fair. It was held from 2018 to 2023. It was hugely popular and had a lot of participation from the region,” he adds.



Between the lines

A Dalit poetry collective brings its English-language showcase to Chennai, using performance, lived experience, and conversation

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English poetry comes with its own set of barriers: the language, the rooms where it is performed, the people who fill those rooms. For Reserved Compartment, a collective of four Dalit poets, the answer has been to walk straight into those spaces and bring their own stories with them.

After initial shows in Mumbai and Bangalore, this weekend, the Reserved Compartment partners with Mahad Productions, an artiste collective in Chennai, to bring its Dalit English poetry showcase to the city. The programme will be centred on protest and anti-caste poetry. The collective – Dr Abhijit Khandkar, Gautam Vegda, Daniel Sukumar, and Aleena, will be joined by Chennai poet C Nivetha for an opening performance in Tamil.

Their poems will speak of caste and protest, but also of food, love, memory, and the small, ordinary details of lived experience. On stage, these personal stories will become a way of asking who gets to speak, who gets to be heard, and who gets to feel at home in a cultural space.

“We are not building a show, we are building a community. After the show in Chennai, we want to invite people for future events, and might even have open mics,” says Daniel who is based

In prose and life The Reserved Compartment’s members Daniel Sukumar, Aleena, Gautam Vegda, and Abhijit Khandkar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



out of Bengaluru.

That sense of community also extends to the spaces they choose to perform in. For Abhijit, who is based in Mumbai, the decision to take the showcase into established cultural venues is deliberate. “We try to do our shows in venues that are mainstream or the most sought-after venues in that city. We want to open those spaces for our people, so that they can also walk

into those spaces and experience how it feels,” he says.

“Spoken word in India is basically run by upper-caste people who have access to fancy cafes where many people cannot just go, buy a coffee for ₹200 and sit and listen to poetry,” says Daniel. The collective also sets aside community tickets at every show, allowing those who may not be able to afford a ticket to attend.

The four poets bring their identities into their work without allowing them to become its only subject.

Daniel, for instance, writes about his mother’s favourite dish, and even his grandfather’s habit of collecting coconut shells. “Most of the time we feel that this unique to us, but when you discuss this on a larger platform, people resonate with it,” he says.

While the poems are rooted in lived experience, Aleena is wary of reducing them to caste narratives alone. “What we are doing through our poems is just telling our truths to power, and hopefully those personal truths resonate with the public. The personal becomes public and political,” she says.



We are not building a show, we are building a community. After the show in Chennai, we want to invite people for future events, and might even have open mics

DANIEL SUKUMAR
Poet

For Aleena, who is based in Kochi and began writing poetry in Malayalam before moving to English, the interaction with an audience is as important as the performance itself. “It is catharsis. You feel seen, you feel heard. The interactive sessions are interesting and free-flowing,” she says.

This showcase will be hosted by the Reserved Compartment on August 22, between 6pm and 9pm at Medai, The Stage. For tickets log on to @thereservedcompartment on Instagram.



Woven legacy

Here is an opportunity to explore the rich textile heritage of Tamil Nadu through a rare collection of saris curated by Julie Wayne, a French connoisseur and scholar of Tamil crafts and textiles. Titled Kodu, Kattam, Korvai: The Saris from the Houses of Chettinadu, the exhibition offers a glimpse into a textile tradition that has largely faded from contemporary memory.

The exhibition draws attention to the distinctive visual language and design vocabulary of the Chettinad sari tradition. In Tamil, kodu refers to a line, kattam to a check or grid, while korvai refers to the intricate technique of joining the body and border of a sari on the loom through a precise interlocking method.

The collection features rare and significant saris that once belonged to Chettiar families in Chettinad, offering insights into their aesthetic sensibilities, craftsmanship, and textile traditions. The exhibition is presented in collaboration with the Indian Institute of Crafts and Design, Jaipur.

@DakshinaChitra, Muttukadu, August 21 to 30, 10am to 5pm.

KACHCHI MITTI

A conscious curation of sustainable fashion brands handpicked by Sanchita Ghosh

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Knot out

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It's the season of romance in Tamil cinema. After a drought of good romance dramas and rom-coms, several titles like *Idhayam Murali*, *Vishwanath & Sons*, *Once More*, and *Hi* are in the limelight. Joining this list is *Pyaar Prema Kalyanam* (PPK), the Netflix film set to release on August 21.

"I am happy that many rom-coms featuring young actors are coming out, which is good because these become stories the youth can relate to," says Elan, who has directed and starred in the lead in PPK. Saanve Megghana, who is

Elan and Saanve Megghana on this week's Tamil release *Pyaar Prema Kalyanam*, which flips the script on traditional gender roles

playing the female lead opposite Elan, feels glad that many rom-coms like *With Love* have performed well. "I have always been a fan of the genre. So I think I manifested being in a rom-com like this," she says with a wide smile.

The very title of *Pyaar Prema Kalyanam* is a play on Elan's directorial debut, the 2018 Harish Kalyan-starrer *Pyaar Prema Kaadhal*. Elan directed that film when he was in his early 20s, and looking back, he believes a film like that had to be done at that age. "It was such a wild film, and we didn't think about a lot of things, like, for instance, the political correctness of it all. Also, I dared to write and shoot intimate scenes. I thought, why shouldn't I show a couple

kissing? But now I have become a filmmaker who has decided not to show all that (*laughs*). This new PPK is a film we want everyone in the family to watch together," he says.

The new PPK has an original screenplay by Nivedita Pohankar, whose sister Aaditi Pohankar played one of the female leads in Elan's last film, *Star*. "Aaditi, Nivedita and I have been friends since even before *Star*. This is a story Nivedita told me randomly at a dinner. She said, 'A woman runs away after getting married.' I asked, 'Why?' and she said, 'Because she wonders why she must go live at his place; so she asks him to live at her place.' Elan instantly liked the idea and suggested Nivedita, a writer and short filmmaker, to flesh it out

In laws and gain

Saanve Megghana and Elan in a still from *Pyaar Prema Kalyanam*. NETFLIX

into a feature-length script.

In the film, Saanve plays Pavithra, a young newlywed woman who refuses to entertain the thought of moving in with her in-laws. She wonders why the men can't do it – a thought millions of women go through. While playing the character, Saanve understood how differently many women handle their emotions. "I understood how many women are conditioned to suppress their emotions. As Saanve, I speak up only when needed. But Pavi speaks up no matter what, and she doesn't think it is wrong."

For Elan, PPK realises a lifelong desire to work in front of the camera. In an earlier chat ahead of *Star*, he had mentioned how he wished to realise his father's dream of becoming a hero. "Acting is a wish, but filmmaking continues to be my passion," he had said, and it seems like the time has come for him to realise that wish. He calls it a work of destiny. "Earlier, my motto was, 'Take as much time you need, but ensure when you do it, it's your best.' But now, my idea is that you should keep doing something. When we do that, we will start learning new lessons, which in turn will help us do our best."

Now, it is obvious that *Pyaar Prema Kalyanam* takes a light-hearted look at traditional gender roles with a quirky subversion. And so, the ultimate result of the film now rests on how neatly it resolves the conflict. "Both the writer and I had a lot of confusion with respect to the resolution. We had a few options before arriving at the one you will see in the film," says Elan, adding that he doesn't wish to tell the audiences what to do or not do. "I believe we should just initiate an argument; we shouldn't give solutions. Each viewer should find their own solutions."

Pyaar Prema Kalyanam is set to premiere on Netflix on August 21



Priya Bhavani Shankar talks about *Irumudi*, her upcoming Telugu film co-starring Ravi Teja

Playing it right

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Call it instinct or the knack of identifying a script that holds promise, actor Priya Bhavani Shankar exudes confidence when she talks about *Irumudi*. "It will be among the best Telugu films in recent years," she says about the film directed by Shiva Nirvana and starring Ravi Teja, releasing in theatres on August 21.

Priya is a familiar face in Telugu cinema, having acted in *Kalyanam Kamaneeyam*, *Zebra*, and the *Dhootha* web series, though Tamil cinema has been her mainstay. "My effort has always been to choose films where my character is significant to the story, irrespective of the screentime. I've consciously avoided decorative characters. Some films may have worked, others may not have, but my effort has been constant."

Irumudi came her way through the production house, Mythri Movie Makers. "I liked the story narrated by Shiva Nirvana and had a long discussion with him. It was evident that the story revolves around the father-daughter bond shared by Ravi Teja and Nakshatra's characters. I was concerned that my character might be rendered invisible.

Shiva was receptive to my thoughts and when we arrived at a consensus, I came on board."

She describes her character, Kaveri, as an antithesis to her real-life personality. "It is a rural family drama and we often hear about women like Kaveri who are docile and naive. She is also the grounding force when there is too much drama between the father and the daughter," says Priya. On a fun note, she shares her mother's observations during the film's promotions. "I had to draw the *muggu* with Suma Kanakala, in the video. My mom found that amusing since I rarely do it in reality."

Priya debuted in Tamil cinema with *Meyaadha Maan* in 2017 and says she took it one day at a time. "My focus was to enjoy the process of acting. I did not want to prove anything to anyone."

Currently working on the sequel to *Dhootha*, apart from the Tamil films *Demonte Colony 3* and *Maragadha Naanayam 2*, Priya acknowledges that her nine-year journey in cinema has whizzed past with a speed that she could not keep track of.

In the last nine years, Priya says she learnt to assess scripts better as she evolved. "I am not embarrassed about any of my earlier films but I think I have evolved as a person and as an actor."



Reflection in verse

Lyricist Irshad Kamil breaks down the process of working on the recent earworms from *Main Vaapas Aaunga*

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Irshad Kamil writes about love with a rare demystifying quality. He invokes its irresolvable charm with expressions echoed in the everyday – like in 'Tum Se Hi' from *Jab We Met* or 'Tum Jo Aaye Zindagi Mein' from *Once Upon a Time in Mumbai* – while also keeping room for a touch of quirk as seen in 'Isq Risk' from *Mere Brother Ki Dulhan* and underlining the feeling of innocence in 'Jug Ghoomeya' from *Sultan*. His collaborations with Imtiaz Ali are particularly striking, seeming to come from a deeply personal space and swiftly becoming the voice of Jordan, Ved, Chamkila and Keenu. Irshad, however, opines that all of his songs come from a personal space.

"It is just that Imtiaz and I have consistently worked together for years and so it gets underlined more in that case," he tells *The Hindu* over a long phone conversation. "For me, even 'Dil

Diya Gallan', 'Jug Ghoomeya' and 'Isq Risk' have come from the heart. And all of these are from Ali Abbas Zafar films. So, my effort has always been to write all songs with a sense of personal belonging."

Even then, there is something different about the songs of *Chamkila* and *Main Vaapas Aaunga* – the two recent Imtiaz Ali films set in Punjab. Irshad, who hails from the State as well, says that these stories feel closer to him. "They are in my veins. I have grown up listening to tales of the Partition and the songs of Chamkila were an active part of my teenage years," he adds. Due to a sense of familiarity, he didn't have to make an effort to recognise the characters or understand their psychology. "I just had to translate my own feelings into the songs, because you can't lie to yourself."

The lyricist also acknowledges the wider scope present in *Main*



Different layers

A still from *Main Vaapas Aaunga*; (below) Irshad Kamil. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Vaapas Aaunga, which allowed for greater exploration. "In *MVA*, the situation was unique, which made the writing process fun and exciting. I recently also wrote for *Krishnavataram*, which was something I hadn't done before. When you work on something entirely new, your involvement unknowingly becomes more."

That sense of exploration, for Irshad, is ultimately rooted in one simple idea: a song must first find a way to the listener. He explains what makes a good song: "Identification is the key to the success of a song. When someone identifies themselves with a piece of art, there is an automatic liking generated towards it. So, a good song gets translated to the point-of-view of every person," he says.

That's what is reflected in abundance in *MVA*, where the specificity of the trauma of the Partition finds a universal release in 'Vo Nahin', a song that captures the longing of Keenu, who gets separated from his lover due to the violence of the Partition. Irshad wanted to infuse a feeling of 'missing someone' into the song. "I like to add multiple layers in my songs. The idea of 'Vo Nahin' came with that thread, which can be woven to mean many things. So, the song can be seen as a plea to the beloved and a representation of the pain of the Partition."

Innocence and simplicity are recurring traits of Irshad's song and poetry, which don't rest on the weight of difficult words to bloom with meaning. He balances even the Arabic roots of the word 'Saiyaara' in the title track from Mohit Suri's film and follows it up with images resting in ease. "I don't like using difficult words in my songs because I am writing them for common folks. They should be able to understand me. *Mera vichar bada hona chahiye, shabd nahi* (My thought should be greater not my word)," he says.

Main Vaapas Aaunga is currently streaming on Netflix



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